THE

BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT PLAYBOOK

FOR TRAINING & CONSULTING PROFESSIONALS

Corporate Trainers · Business Coaches · HR Consultants · Management Consultancies

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Strategy · Sales Process · Client Psychology

How to grow a training or consulting practice from founder-led hustle to a repeatable, relationship-driven growth engine.

Synthesised from
Rain Making · *The Trusted Advisor* · *The Platinum Rule*

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INTRODUCTION: WHO THIS PLAYBOOK IS FOR

You started your practice because you're good at what you do. You can transform a room of disengaged managers into a high-performing team. You can see organisational problems that HR departments have been circling for years. But somewhere between delivering programmes and trying to grow the business, something got stuck.

The pipeline dries up between engagements. You're too busy preparing slides and running workshops to market the practice. When a major programme ends, you scramble for the next client. You know you should be "out there" more, but every hour spent networking feels like an hour stolen from programme design. And when you do try to sell, it feels awkward — like you're pitching rather than helping.

This playbook is for you.

It's built specifically for Malaysian training and consulting professionals — corporate trainers, executive coaches, HR consultants, management consultancies, leadership development firms, and any practice where your knowledge and delivery skill is your product.

It synthesises three of the most respected books on professional services growth into a single, integrated system you can start using tomorrow. No theory without application. No generic advice that ignores how business actually works in Malaysia.

> *If you recognise yourself in any of the above, keep reading. This playbook will change how you think about growing your company.*

SECTION 1: THE GROWTH ENGINE

Every professional services business runs on one formula, whether the founder knows it or not:

$$\text{Revenue} = N \times B \times F$$

Every activity you do, every meeting you take, every article you write should improve at least one of these three variables. Growing all three simultaneously creates geometric growth.

What Each Variable Means

- **N (Network Size):** HR directors, L&D managers, CEOs, and business owners who know your practice exists. For solo practitioners, this sits around 50–80. Target: 200–300.

- **B (% Buyers):** The percentage of your network who actually book you. For solo practitioners with early-stage relationships, this is typically 2–3%. Target: 5–8% through deeper trust and programme-based engagements.
- **F (Average Fee):** Your average engagement value. Most trainers undercharge because they sell individual workshop days instead of programmes. Moving from one-off sessions to annual training calendars or transformation programmes can triple this number.

The Compound Effect

Scenario	Network (N)	Buyers (B)	Avg Fee (F)	Revenue
Current state	80	2.5%	RM 8,000	RM 16,000
12-month target	250	6.5%	RM 35,000	RM 568,750

Same founder. Same team. Same expertise. The difference is a system that deliberately grows all three variables instead of hoping the phone rings.

The Trust Equation

Trust is the mechanism that converts N into B:

$$\text{Trust} = (\text{Credibility} + \text{Reliability} + \text{Intimacy}) \div \text{Self-Orientation}$$

- **Credibility:** Your qualifications, certifications, client portfolio, published work, professional endorsements.
- **Reliability:** Do you deliver when you say you will? Consistency in small things builds enormous trust.
- **Intimacy:** Does the client feel safe telling you the real problem?
- **Self-Orientation (keep LOW):** Is your first instinct “how do I upsell?” or “what does this client actually need?”

> *Key insight: Most firms over-invest in Credibility while ignoring Intimacy and Self-Orientation. The firms that win aren’t always the most qualified — they’re the ones clients trust most.*

How Trust Gets Weighted by Personality

Style	Trusts Through	Your Approach
Director (fast-paced, task-focused)	Credibility + Reliability	Be concise. Deliver results. Don’t waste their time.

Socialiser (fast-paced, people-focused)	Intimacy + Credibility	Build personal rapport. Show enthusiasm. Be visible.
Relater (slow-paced, people-focused)	Intimacy + Reliability	Be patient. Don't rush. Show you care personally.
Thinker (slow-paced, task-focused)	Credibility (data-heavy)	Provide evidence. Be thorough. Let them analyse.

Three Layers, One Playbook

- **Layer 1 — The System:** What activities to do and when. How to grow N × B × F.
- **Layer 2 — The Philosophy:** Who to be in every interaction. Show don't claim. Listen before solving.
- **Layer 3 — The Personalisation:** How to deliver Layer 1 using Layer 2 calibrated to each person's behavioural style.

SECTION 2: MINDSET & IDENTITY

Before tactics, rewire how you think about selling.

Sales = Survival (Founder Edition)

If you don't sell, the practice doesn't exist. Whether you sell direct or through referral networks, you are the growth engine. The sooner you accept this as a core part of your professional identity, the sooner your practice starts growing.

The Time Excuse

You're genuinely busy. But everyone who succeeds at business development is equally busy. The difference isn't available hours — it's what you treat as urgent versus important.

Delivering client work feels urgent because there's a deadline. Writing a LinkedIn article doesn't feel urgent because nobody's waiting. But that article, published consistently over six months, puts you in front of decision-makers who have never heard of your practice.

The Numbers Game

- **Cold approaches to get one meeting:** ~15–20
- **Meetings to get one engagement:** ~3–5
- **Proposals to get one PO:** ~2–3

Work backward from your revenue target. Three outreach attempts per week. Completely manageable — but only if you do it consistently.

Porpoising and the Alice Trap

> *Porpoising: the radical swing from too much work to too little, caused by stop-start marketing. The fix: always have at least one marketing activity running, no matter how busy you are.*

> *The Alice Trap: getting so busy delivering that you never transition to selling. The professional who always chooses billable work over marketing is optimising for this month at the expense of next quarter.*

Your Credibility Stack

Credibility is expertise plus presence. Your stack, in order of impact:

1. Recognised Certifications — HRDF-registered trainer, ICF-credentialed coach, certified facilitator credentials. These are the qualifications HR departments check before processing your PO.

2. Methodology Credentials — certified in DISC, MBTI, Gallup StrengthsFinder, Design Thinking, Lean Six Sigma, or other frameworks. These signal structured, evidence-based delivery.
3. Client Portfolio — when an HR director hears you've delivered programmes for recognised companies, their brain processes "credible" faster than any certification.
4. Domain Knowledge Depth — be the most knowledgeable person in the room about your specialisation. When you diagnose an organisational issue in a way that helps them understand their people problem better than they did before, nobody asks about your academic background.
5. Visible Enthusiasm — when you light up talking about leadership development, team dynamics, or organisational change, that energy is a credibility signal that can't be faked — and for trainers, it's also a preview of your delivery style.

> *When the qualification question comes up: state your experience, certifications, endorsements, and client list — then move on. Defensiveness is self-orientation.*

Sayings to Keep in Your Head

- "It's about the client, not about me."
- "Who am I thinking about right now?"
- "The answer is a better question."
- "The problem is rarely what the client said it was at first."
- "I don't have to prove myself every 10 seconds."
- "Am I claiming trust or demonstrating it?"

SECTION 3: GETTING KNOWN

One-to-many activities that build reputation. Core principle: show, don't claim.

Writing & Publishing

Published articles prove expertise better than any brochure. Write for your audience's problems.

What to Write

- "5 Signs Your Leadership Programme Isn't Changing Behaviour" — targeted at HR directors and L&D managers
- "Why One-Day Workshops Don't Work: The Case for Learning Journeys" — positions programme-based engagement as the natural next step
- "How Malaysian Companies Can Reduce Employee Turnover by 30% Through Better Manager Development" — targets HR decision-makers
- "The True Cost of Skipping Needs Assessment Before Training" — uses anonymised data from actual engagements

Where to Publish

- LinkedIn articles (immediate, free, reaches your exact audience)
- MIHRM (Malaysian Institute of Human Resource Management) publications
- HRDF newsletter and knowledge portal
- SME Corp publications (SME development angle)
- Your company blog with proper SEO

The Leverage Play

Every article becomes a mailer, a handout, a social post, and a credibility proof in proposals. One piece of writing, multiple outputs.

Speaking

Topics that generate leads:

- "Building a Learning Culture: A Practical Framework for HR Leaders"
- "Beyond Kirkpatrick: Measuring Real Behavioural Change After Training"
- "The ROI Conversation: How to Justify L&D Spend to Your CFO"

> *Give the speech → convert to article → convert to PDF mailer → send to target list → use in proposals. One effort, five outputs.*

Training Workshops as Lead Generation

- Limit to 15–20 attendees
- Use real (anonymised) case data

- One-on-one conversations during breaks
- Follow up within 48 hours
- Track: attended → engaged → need → CRM opportunity

Social Content That Builds Credibility

DON'T	DO
"We completed a leadership workshop for 40 managers. Contact us for your training needs!"	"Here's what happens when you run a leadership programme without a needs assessment first. This company spent RM 80K on communication skills training. The real problem was role clarity. Most HR teams don't discover this until the post-training survey comes back flat."

The first is advertising. The second demonstrates expertise.

Direct Mail & Email (Quarterly Cadence)

- **Q1:** "2026 L&D Planning Guide" — one-page reference covering HRDF claim procedures, budget benchmarks, and programme design principles
- **Q2:** Case study mailer — anonymised results showing behavioural change and business impact post-programme
- **Q3:** HRDF update — changes in claimable schemes, new levy rates, emerging priority areas
- **Q4:** "Planning Your 2027 Training Calendar" — timed to annual budget season

Every mailer gives something useful. None say "contact us." That's the "go first" principle.

SECTION 4: BUILDING & MAINTAINING YOUR NETWORK

Who You Need to Know

Category	Examples	Why They Matter
Direct Buyers	HR directors, L&D managers, CEOs, business owners, department heads	They sign POs or approve training budgets
Influencers	Line managers, team leads, previous participants	They recommend trainers to HR after a good experience
Referral Partners	Complementary consultants, recruitment firms, other trainers in different domains	They encounter your prospects in every HR meeting
Gatekeepers	Procurement, HR executives (not directors), HRDF administrators	They control vendor registration and PO processing
Knowledge Sources	HRDF contacts, MIHRM leaders, corporate L&D community	They tell you about upcoming training budgets and RFPs early

Trade Associations

Join and get active. Volunteer for committees.

- MIHRM — volunteer for events or committees. Direct access to HR directors across industries
- MIM (Malaysian Institute of Management) — management professionals who buy training
- ICF Malaysia Chapter — coaching community with referral potential
- SME Corp networks — access to SME owners who are your direct buyers
- Industry-specific chambers — FMM, AMCHAM, EUROCHAM give access to MNC L&D budgets

Network Quality

Target 200–300 contacts. Assess each across four dimensions:

- **Purchasing power:** Can they hire you?
- **Access & influence:** Connected to decision-makers?
- **Information value:** Early opportunity intelligence?
- **Referral willingness:** Actively recommend you?

> *The Oscar Principle: always introduce people who can help each other. Connectors get called first.*

Style-Adapted Relationship Maintenance

Style	Maintenance Approach	Frequency
Director	Short, results-focused updates.	Monthly email, quarterly call
Socialiser	Social engagement. Comment on posts. Invite to events.	Bi-weekly touchpoint
Relater	Personal check-ins.	Monthly personal message
Thinker	Technical content. Research, data.	Quarterly deep-value email

SECTION 5: THE SALES PROCESS

Getting the Meeting

The 4-Touch Outreach Sequence

- **Touch 1 (Day 1):** LinkedIn connection — brief, specific, no pitch
- **Touch 2 (Day 2–3):** Email — value-focused
- **Touch 3 (Day 4–5):** WhatsApp — conversational, brief
- **Touch 4 (Day 7–10):** Phone call — now warm

> *"I noticed [Company] recently restructured their regional teams. Organisations going through structural change often see a dip in manager effectiveness. Would 15 minutes be useful to share what we've seen work in similar transitions?"*

The Learning Call

> *"I'm researching how Malaysian companies approach leadership development for mid-level managers. Could I get 15 minutes of your time to understand your current approach?"*

Running the Meeting

Pre-Meeting Preparation

- Check their style in CRM
- Research their company and challenges
- Prepare first five minutes for their style
- Set intention: "It's about them, not me."

The First Five Minutes

6. Personal link: something specific about their organisation.
7. Agenda statement: "I'd like to understand your approach and share how we've helped similar organisations."
8. Positioning statement: Lead with a RESULT.
9. Stage-setting anecdote: One brief real story. Under 30 seconds.
10. The Big Question: "What keeps you up at night?" Then listen.

Questions That Surface Real Needs

- "What's the biggest people challenge your organisation is facing right now?"
- "How do you currently measure whether training programmes are working?"
- "Have you had programmes that didn't deliver the expected results?"

- “What does your HRDF utilisation look like this year?”
- “If you could change one thing about how your organisation develops its people, what would it be?”

Buying signals:

- **“We’ve been meaning to address our manager pipeline”** — recognised need
- **“Our HRDF levy is piling up”** — budget pressure to spend = urgent
- **“Last trainer just did generic slides”** — competitor weakness
- **“The CEO is asking about our talent bench”** — top-down mandate

> *The “What else?” technique: The real problem usually surfaces second or third, not first.*

Framing the Problem

DON'T	DO
Client: "We need a 2-day leadership workshop." Vendor: "We can do that for RM 8,000 per day."	Adviser: "A 2-day workshop is a starting point. What you’re really trying to solve is sustainable behaviour change in 25 managers who influence 200 employees. Two days alone gives knowledge transfer but rarely changes habits. The real value is a 3-month learning journey with coaching follow-through that actually moves your engagement scores."

How Framing Shifts by Style

- **Director:** Business impact in one line. “This isn’t a training cost. It’s a manager effectiveness investment that shows up in your turnover numbers.”
- **Socialiser:** Vision and status. “Imagine presenting your CEO a leadership programme with measurable before-and-after impact data.”
- **Relater:** Reassurance. “You’ve been investing in your people. This is about adding the follow-through layer that turns a good workshop into lasting change.”
- **Thinker:** Evidence chain. Walk through the forgetting curve data, show why single-event training has a 15% retention rate, and present the programme design with measurement methodology.

Giving Advice Without Losing the Client

DON'T	DO
"Your approach is fundamentally flawed. You	"Based on what we’ve seen, there are areas that

should have addressed this years ago."	could use attention. Let me walk you through options and you decide what makes sense."

Advise clients like you're helping your parents — respectful, honest, always their decision.

Winning the Work

Proposals by Style

Style	Format	What They Read First
Director	2 pages max. Price upfront.	Price and timeline
Socialiser	Visual. Testimonials.	Who else you've worked with
Relater	Detailed process. Reassuring.	Implementation process
Thinker	Comprehensive. Methodology.	Technical approach

Handling "Price Is Too High"

- **Director:** What you get for the money. "Our fee includes needs assessment, customised design, and 90-day coaching follow-through. The next cheapest trainer gives you a generic slide deck."
- **Socialiser:** Relationship reassurance. "I hear you. Let me adjust the scope. The quality of facilitation won't change."
- **Relater:** Process comfort. "Let's start with one cohort and expand based on results. No commitment beyond the pilot."
- **Thinker:** ROI data. "Here's the comparison: our programme fee vs. the cost of replacing one disengaged manager."

When You Lose

- Debrief within 48 hours
- Find the real reason
- Track patterns in CRM
- Follow up in 6 months

SECTION 6: DELIVERING & GROWING

During Delivery

- Confirm logistics 48 hours before. Send pre-work materials a week ahead.
- Provide same-day summary and photos after every session — HR needs these for internal reporting.
- Don't oversell the transformation. If a team is already functioning well, say so. The HR director who hears honest assessment trusts your diagnosis when issues DO surface.
- Include a "What's Next" section in every post-programme report — genuine development recommendations, not a sales pitch.
- Help them USE your deliverables — coach HR on presenting results to their CEO, building the case for continued investment, justifying HRDF claims.

The 4 Levels of Client Relationship

Level	Description	Revenue Implication
1. Service Provider	You do what you're asked.	One-off, easily replaced
2. Capable Expert	They trust your judgment.	Repeat work, some flexibility
3. Valued Resource	They seek your input beyond scope.	Annual contracts, premium pricing
4. Trusted Adviser	They involve you in strategy.	Multi-year partnerships, referrals

Post-Delivery Follow-Up

- **30 days:** "How are the participants applying the frameworks from the workshop? Any resistance points I can help troubleshoot?"
- **90 days:** "Have you noticed any shift in the team dynamics we discussed? Happy to do a quick pulse check."
- **Ongoing:** Share relevant updates. "HRDF just announced changes to the claimable scheme structure — might affect your 2027 training plan. Happy to walk you through the implications."

The Portal Service Strategy

The entry engagement for training and consulting firms is the needs assessment or diagnostic workshop. It's affordable, answers an immediate question, gives you access to multiple stakeholders across the organisation, and naturally leads to a full programme design.

The Conversion Path

Needs assessment → findings reveal real gaps → customised programme design → delivery across multiple cohorts → coaching follow-through → annual L&D partnership → expansion to other departments.

Growing Accounts

- **Expand:** New service, same person — easiest
- **Broaden:** Same service, new person — medium
- **Diversify:** New service, new person — hardest

SECTION 7: YOUR 12-MONTH PLAN

Growth Formula Targets

Variable	Current	3-Month	6-Month	12-Month
N (Network)	___	___	___	___
B (% Buyers)	___	___	___	___
F (Avg Fee)	RM ___	RM ___	RM ___	RM ___
Revenue	RM ___	RM ___	RM ___	RM ___

The 3 Things to Do Tomorrow

11. Write one article. Publish on LinkedIn within two weeks.
12. Apply to speak at one industry event in the next three months.
13. Send one value-add email to 10 target contacts — not a pitch, but useful content.

QUICK REFERENCE

60-Second Style Identification

14. Fast-paced/assertive (Direct) or slow-paced/reserved (Indirect)?
15. Task-focused (Guarded) or people-focused (Open)?

	Task-Focused	People-Focused
Fast-Paced	DIRECTOR: Decisive, impatient	SOCIALISER: Enthusiastic, big-picture
Slow-Paced	THINKER: Analytical, cautious	RELATER: Patient, consensus-seeking

Style Warnings

- **Socialiser:** They'll say yes enthusiastically then delay paperwork.
- **Relater:** "Let me think about it" may mean no.
- **Thinker:** May keep asking for data to delay decisions.
- **Director:** If you're slow, they move on. Respond same day.

Pre-Meeting Checklist

- Check their style in CRM
- Research: company, recent changes, context
- Prepare first five minutes for their style
- Set intention: "It's about them, not me."

Self-Test Before Any Marketing Material

- Am I telling them I'm good, or showing evidence?
- Is this about my company, or the client?
- Would I trust a company that said this?
- Is there a specific result I could use instead of a general claim?
- Am I giving something valuable, or just asking for something?

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